CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Holocaust Inversion in British Politics: The Case of David Ward

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INTRODUCTION

Antisemitism in Britain is no longer the preserve of the political far right as it was throughout much of the 20th century. It is more commonly found on the left of the political spectrum where it masks itself as anti-Zionism and uses the language of human rights in the "fight for Palestine."[1] The 2006 All-Party Parliamentary Group Against Antisemitism found that Holocaust inversion—the provocative comparison between the brutal and genocidal Nazi treatment of the Jews with the policies and practices of the Israeli state towards the Palestinians and the associated idea that "the Jews" should have learnt a moral lesson from the Holocaust—is commonplace among the British left and Palestine solidarity groups, particularly during periods of conflict in the Middle East.[2] Indeed, the portrayal of Israelis/Zionists/Jews as Nazis was a prominent feature of protests against the Iraq War, Operation Cast Lead, Operation Pillar of Defence, and most recently, Operation Protective Edge. In one month alone—July 2014—the Community Security Trust recorded 101 explicit references to the Holocaust, the majority of which were an attempt to equate Israel's defensive actions in Gaza with the crimes of the Nazis.[3]

The current British vogue to account for the Israel-Palestinian conflict as a kind of Holocaust with the Israelis/Zionists/Jews portrayed as the "new" Nazis and the Palestinians portrayed as the "new" Jews is perhaps not surprising given the trope's British provenance. While it is commonly assumed that Holocaust inversion originated in the Soviet polemics of the 1960s and 1970s, historian and antisemitism scholar Robert Wistrich has pointed out that the trope first emerged in the British Foreign Office as it sought to restrict survivors of the Holocaust from entering Palestine.[4] Specifically, the Englishman Sir John Glubb Pasha, Supreme Commander of the Arab Jordanian Legion in Israel's War of Independence, promulgated the idea that the Jews had anticipated Hitler's master race theory.[5] He claimed that the

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